

AIRING THEIR DEMANDS
Tribal organisations hold an 'Ek Chintan, Ek Manthan' programme in Margao, Goa, May 25

Congress government, and the BJP was voted to power.

Per the 2011 Census, North Goa has a tribal population of 56,606, which is 6.92 per cent of the population, while it is 92,669 or 14.47 per cent of the population in South Goa. Tribals, including Christians among them, comprise 10.23 per cent of Goa's population. The Gouly Dhangar community is also seeking inclusion in the ST category.

Ravindra Velip, vice-president of the Gakuved Federation, an umbrella body that derives its name from the Gauda, Velip, Kunbi and Dhangar communities, charged the Goa government with wilful tardiness. "Delay in approving the demand for political reservation will perpetuate injustice on these communities," he says.

However, in the recent budget session of the Goa assembly, chief minister Pramod Sawant promised that his government would ensure political quota for STs by the 2027 assembly election. A senior state government officer says that the Directorate of Tribal Welfare, Government of Goa, had recommended that four seats in the 40-member assembly be reserved for STs. He says that a proposal was sent to the Union government on 24 May. "The Union government will now appoint a delimitation commission, which will visit Goa, study the issue and submit its report, after which suggestions and objections will be called for before finalising the recommendation," he said, though he stopped short of giving a timeline.

Yuri Alemao of the Congress, who is leader of the Opposition, says, "ST communities should get reservation immediately." He alleges that tribals were "used" by BJP for votes.

The boycott call has revealed fault lines amongst tribal leaders. "A boycott (of the LS polls) won't solve the issue," says former minister Prakash Velip, who heads the UTAA. Velip, who met CM Sawant with associates, says they had asked him to organise a meeting with the Union home minister Amit Shah.

Prabhakar Gaonkar, president of the BJP's Goa ST Morcha, points to Sawant's assurance of the quota by 2027. "The calls for a boycott of polls will have no effect. The state government is working on (ensuring political reservation for tribals)," he says.

Sandesh Prabhudesai, journalist and political analyst, says tribals are the 'mool goenkars' or original settlers of Goa. "It's lamentable they have to fight for reservation," he adds. Prabhudesai feels politicians are stalling the quota move as they fear their constituencies will be reserved. ■

Goa's BJP government has promised political quota for tribals by 2027

UTTAR PRADESH

CORRIDOR FOR THE FAITHFUL

By Prashant Srivastava

Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath is betting big on religious tourism to give a facelift to his state, Uttar Pradesh. The success of the Kashi Vishwanath temple corridor, where tourists and pilgrims are descending in hordes, has prompted plans for three new corridors—the Vindhyavasini in Mirzapur, Mathura-Vrindavan and the Nath circuit in Bareilly.

Among the three, the Vindhyavasini corridor is where all the focus is currently, with construction work on at war footing. The Vindhyavasini temple, also known as Vindhyachal Dham, is dedicated to the goddess of the same name. One of the Shakti Peetha temples, it is situated on the banks of the river Ganga in Mirzapur district in eastern UP.

Besides the beautification of the temple, a 50-feet-wide parikrama route and "world-class facilities" for pilgrims are on the cards. Work on the Rs 225 crore project started in March 2022, but has stepped up pace of late. Officers in charge of the project had earlier been told to wrap it up by December 2023—in good time for the 2024 general election—so workers were labouring away in three shifts. Government officials now say it will be completed ahead of schedule, by July-end. After the corridor work is done, the temple will be able to accommodate some 5,000 devotees at any given time. Currently, close to a million people visit the temple on occasions such as Navaratri.

Pink stone from Ahraura in Mirzapur is being used for the 170 pillars on the *parkauta*